

UniSeek

Primary User Personas

DOCUMENT	STATUS	FOCUS
Persona Brief	Working Draft	College discovery and validation

Persona Framework

How to read these personas

These personas represent decision-making styles rather than demographic groups. This better reflects UniSeek's purpose: helping students discover and evaluate colleges through personalized, evidence-backed recommendations.

Persona Priority

#	Persona	Product relevance
1	The Overwhelmed Achiever	Primary persona; strongest need for personalized, transparent recommendations.
2	The Explorer & Validator	Directly aligned with discovery, comparison, and confidence-building.
3	The First-Generation Student	Benefits most from guided questions and accessible explanations.
4	The Budget-Conscious Family	Strong use case for cost, value, and outcomes data.

Primary Personas

1

The Overwhelmed Achiever

PRIMARY PERSONA

BACKGROUND

High GPA, solid extracurriculars, and an existing shortlist, but struggles to narrow the options down.

FRUSTRATIONS

College websites sound identical; rankings lack nuance; online opinions conflict.

GOALS

Find colleges that genuinely fit; reduce research time; understand every recommendation.

VALUES

Transparency, evidence, personalization, and trustworthy reasoning.

UNISEEK VALUE

“Show me schools I probably haven’t considered - and prove why they belong on my list.”

2

The First-Generation Student

GUIDANCE-DRIVEN PERSONA

BACKGROUND

Limited family experience with higher education and little guidance through admissions.

FRUSTRATIONS

Does not know where to start; terminology is confusing; fears making the wrong choice.

GOALS

Build a balanced college list; understand the process; make informed decisions.

VALUES

Guidance, simplicity, education, and confidence.

UNISEEK VALUE

“Walk me through the process instead of assuming I already know it.”

Primary Personas

3

The Budget-Conscious Family

VALUE-DRIVEN PERSONA

BACKGROUND

Cost and long-term value are major factors in the college decision.

FRUSTRATIONS

Comparing costs is difficult; ROI is unclear; net-price calculators vary.

GOALS

Find affordable colleges with strong outcomes and scholarship opportunities.

VALUES

Financial transparency, graduation rates, and career outcomes.

UNISEEK VALUE

“Don't just tell me it's a good school - tell me if it's worth the investment.”

4

The Explorer & Validator

DISCOVERY-DRIVEN PERSONA

BACKGROUND

May have only a few schools in mind - or already has a list but wants reassurance and hidden gems.

FRUSTRATIONS

Recommendation sites repeat the same schools; rankings feel shallow; advice from friends, parents, and the internet conflicts.

GOALS

Discover overlooked colleges; validate existing choices; compare tradeoffs.

VALUES

Discovery, evidence, comparisons, and transparency.

UNISEEK VALUE

“Help me discover better options, validate my choices, and explain every recommendation.”

Secondary Persona

S	Parents	
	INFLUENTIAL STAKEHOLDER	
	BACKGROUND Often help guide or fund the college decision, even when the student is the primary product user.	GOALS Help their child make an informed decision and understand the financial and practical implications.
	FRUSTRATIONS Recommendations can feel opaque; costs and outcomes are difficult to compare; they may distrust unexplained AI output.	VALUES Cost, safety, graduation outcomes, long-term value, and transparent reasoning.
UNISEEK VALUE <i>"Give me enough evidence to trust the recommendations my child is using."</i>		

Product Role

Student-led, parent-legible

Parents are not the primary users, but they benefit from UniSeek's evidence-backed recommendations and transparent reasoning. The experience should remain student-centered while making its logic clear enough for a parent to understand and trust.